

Eurypterus

you-RIP-teruss

- **When** 420 million years ago (Late Silurian)
- **Fossil location** United States
- **Habitat** Shallow seas
- **Length** Up to 4 in (10 cm)

This small sea scorpion was less well armed than the fearsome *Pterygotus*. It used prickly legs to pull tiny animals toward its fangs, which it then used to tear the victim to shreds. *Eurypterus* hunted on the muddy floors of shallow seas.



Mesolimulus

mee-zo-LIM-you-luss

- **When** 162–145 million years ago (Late Jurassic)
- **Fossil location** Germany
- **Habitat** Shallow ocean waters
- **Length** Up to 3¼–3½ in (8–9 cm), without tail

Mesolimulus is also called a horseshoe crab (though it's more closely related to spiders and scorpions than crabs). It had a huge shell, small, widely spaced eyes, and a stiff tail with a sharp tip, like a spear. It lived on the seafloor, where it hunted worms and shellfish.



LIVING RELATIVE

Modern horseshoe crabs such as *Limulus* are almost exactly like their prehistoric cousins from the Jurassic Period. *Limulus* lives in shallow water off the eastern coast of North America. It swims upside down, as its ancient relative probably did.

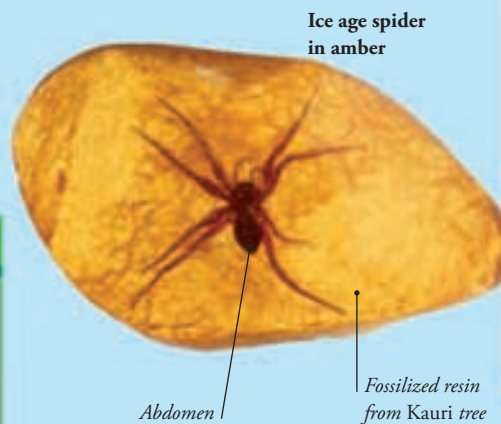
Limulus

Spider

SPY-der

- **When** 400 million years ago (Late Silurian) to now
- **Fossil location** Worldwide
- **Habitat** All land
- **Size** Up to 12 in (30 cm) across

Although the soft and delicate bodies of spiders do not fossilize well, thousands of species have been found, many of them preserved in pebbles of amber—a clear, golden material formed from fossilized pine-tree resin. Spiders are specialized hunters that often use silk traps to capture prey before killing victims with a lethal injection of venom from their fangs. The oldest fossilized spider's web is 100 million years old.



Ice age spider in amber

Abdomen

Fossilized resin from Kauri tree

Proscorpius

pro-SCOR-pee-us

- **When** 400–300 million years ago (Silurian – Carboniferous)
- **Fossil location** Worldwide
- **Habitat** Uncertain
- **Length** 1½ in (4 cm)

The first scorpions lived in the sea rather than on land and breathed through gills. One of the oldest fossils is *Proscorpius* from the Late Silurian Period. This creature's mouth was under its head like that of a horseshoe crab, rather than at the front like a modern scorpion's. It isn't clear whether it lived on land or in water.

